

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

City pushing CPS to refinance debt

School board faces difficult decision on how to balance books in about a week

By **Nell Salzman, Alice Yin and Gregory Royal Pratt**
Chicago Tribune

The city is pushing Chicago Public Schools to refinance about \$240 million in debt to balance its budget for the year, a move that some finance experts argue is fiscally irresponsible.

In a briefing with reporters Tuesday, senior aides to Mayor

Brandon Johnson said the district could get the money released out of an existing debt service fund, which school districts use to pay off debt similar to a mortgage or a construction loan on a house. CPS borrows money by selling bonds and has to pay it back over time.

CPS could then pay it back with expiring tax increment financing money — tax money set aside to spur growth in neighborhoods —

in two to 10 years, Johnson's aides said.

But the city and outgoing CPS chief Pedro Martinez are in a tough spot, financial experts say.

Due to a decline in federal funding and an increase in operating costs, the district is staring down a budget deficit of at least \$500 million for the 2025-26 school year.

In a week, the school board will tasked with a difficult decision about how to balance its books. Board members have received advice from various financial firms and are waiting on another outside

firm's analysis to help understand the implications of that decision.

Six school board members told the Tribune they received an email at the beginning of March from the Board of Education's bond attorney Lewis Greenbaum of Katten Muchin Rosenman warning against using debt to cover operating costs.

"We have reviewed the (Illinois) Constitution and applicable statutes concerning debt issuance by the District and we find no authority for the issuance of debt by the District to fund a budget deficit,"

the email states.

Greenbaum's email talks about the risks and challenges of borrowing under a budget deficit — where the amount of expenditures for the fiscal year is greater than the amount of revenues and reserve funds. Still, CPS' proposal to restructure existing debt is different from issuing new bonds, according to financial experts.

Refinancing debt works in emergency situations, but the MEABF payment is less of an emergency

Turn to Debt, Page 5

Immigration drives local population increases

Census figures show international arrivals outpace departures

By **Robert McCoppin**
Chicago Tribune

The Chicago metropolitan area and Cook County both saw slight increases in population according to the most recent estimate by the U.S. Census Bureau, as international immigration outpaced domestic departures in many big cities nationwide.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metropolitan area grew by 70,762 people — less than 1% — from July 1, 2023, to July 1, 2024. That was the ninth-largest numeric growth of any metropolitan area in the country. But the population of the metropolitan area was still lower than it was five years earlier because of declines during the COVID pandemic. The metro area's population stood at 9,408,576 in 2024, down from 9,454,363 in 2020.

Cook County gained around 40,000 people between 2023 and 2024, or 0.8%, but its population remained 1.8% below its 2020 level.

"Increasingly, population growth in metro areas is being shaped by international migration," said Kristie Wilder, a demographer in the Census Bureau's Population Division. "While births continue to contribute to overall growth, rising net international migration is offsetting the ongoing net domestic outmigration we see in many of these areas."

More than 51,000 immigrants have come to Chicago since 2022, when Texas Gov. Greg Abbott began busing migrants north to the city. The city has spent more than \$600 million on housing and other services for the arrivals, prompting complaints from some residents who wanted to see the resources address chronic community problems.

Cook County remained the second largest county in the union behind Los Angeles County, with just under 5.2 million people.

The collar counties also saw modest growth between 2023 and 2024. DuPage, Kane, Lake, McHenry and Will each gained slightly less than 1%. Fast-growing Kendall County gained 2.1%,

Turn to Census, Page 4

INSIDE

Bears put a focus on the trenches



Veterans Joe Thuney and Jonah Jarrett bring value to Bears that doesn't end on the field. **Chicago Sports**

US weapons again flow into Ukraine

The Trump administration lifted suspension of aid and awaited Russia's response to a proposed ceasefire. **Nation & World**



ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Call made for 8 p.m. teen curfew

People walk through Chicago's Loop shortly after sunset Tuesday. Ald. Brian Hopkins, 2nd, has called for an 8 p.m. teen curfew after a tourist was shot in front of a movie theater about 8:10 p.m. Sunday in the 400 block of North Columbus Drive. **Chicagoland, Page 3**



A view from the Brookfield Zoo's Anniversary Ferris Wheel shows a hazy Chicago skyline on June 18. A new global air quality report places Chicago as the seventh-most polluted major city in the country in 2024, an improvement from second-worst in 2023. **ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Chicago air pollution improves compared to other big US cities

Report: Windy City No. 7 on list for 2024, down from 2nd place

By **Adriana Pérez**
Chicago Tribune

Chicago was the seventh-most polluted major city in the country in 2024, according to a global air quality report released Tuesday. The average annual concentration of small particulate matter in the air led to a 35% decrease in the air pollution levels that had placed the city second in the

previous year's ranking.

"The goal of the report is to raise awareness that eventually will translate into impact around global air pollution levels, and basically just continue to raise the alarm about PM2.5 in particular, and how damaging it is to people's health," said Christi Chester Schroeder, the lead author and an air quality science manager at Swiss air quality technology company IQAir.

On average last year, Chicago's atmosphere had 8.4 micrograms of particulate matter per cubic meter of air, consid-

erably lower than its 2023 average of 13 micrograms. But "that's still a far cry" from the World Health Organization's recommended guideline of 5 micrograms per cubic meter, Schroeder said.

Wildfires in the Canadian province of Quebec during the summer of 2023 contributed to higher levels of PM2.5 that year. Schroeder said other contributors to lower pollution levels could be that the winter of 2023-2024 was the warmest on record for the coun-

Turn to Pollution, Page 5

US and its trading allies are ramping up tariffs

Trump increases tax for steel, aluminum; EU, Canada hit back

By **Josh Boak, Paul Wiseman and Rob Gillies**
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump openly challenged U.S. allies on Wednesday by increasing tariffs on all steel and aluminum imports to 25% as he vowed to take back what he alleged was wealth "stolen" by other countries, drawing quick retaliation from Europe and Canada.

The Republican president's use of tariffs to extract concessions from other nations points toward a possibly destructive trade war and a stark change in America's approach to global leadership. It also has destabilized the stock market and stoked anxiety about an economic downturn.

"The United States of America is going to take back a lot of what was stolen from it by other countries and, frankly, by incompetent U.S. leadership," Trump told reporters on Wednesday. "We're going to take back our wealth, and we're going to take back a lot of the companies that left."

Trump removed all exemptions from his 2018 tariffs on the metals, in addition to increasing the tariffs

Turn to Tariffs, Page 4

